

PROTECTION FOR ANY INGENIOUS DEVICE

THE VENETIAN PATENT STATUTE (1474)



IN CONTEXT

FOCUS

Patent law

BEFORE

500 BCE Chefs in Sybaris in Greece are said to have been granted a year's monopoly on dishes they have invented.

1421 The first known patent on an invention is issued to Filippo Brunelleschi in Florence.

1449 English king Henry VI issues John of Utynam a monopoly on stained glass manufacture.

AFTER

1624 The Statute of Monopolies, which allows patents to be granted for noteworthy inventions, becomes law in England.

1790 The US Patent Act gives inventors an exclusive patent for 14 years.

The Venetian Patent Statute of 1474 marks the true beginning of modern patent law (the law protecting new inventions). Established in the Republic of Venice, it was not the first example of patent protection, but it was the first to establish a comprehensive system that applied to all inventions.

In the early 15th century, the city-states of Renaissance Italy were thriving, and the different states vied to come up with new ideas in the arts, science, and technology. Inventions, after all, could earn money and status. But if ideas could be copied easily the instant they came off the